Volume 3 Issue 2 Autumn 2009

Hollerbeier Haven

Journal of Traditional Deitsch Wisdom

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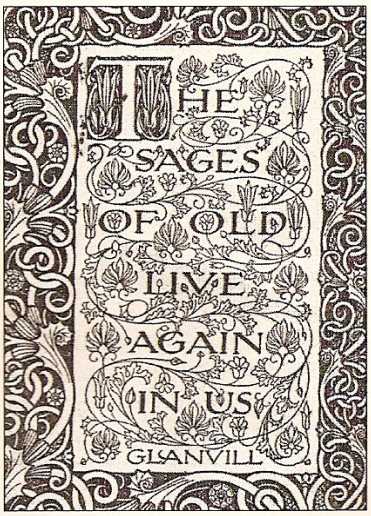
Die Volkstimme



The Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts is recording stories, interviews, memories, and knowledge of the healing traditions of Pow-wow or Braucherei. We are creating an archive of this tradition in order to preserve our heritage and ensure the practice. If you know anyone who practices or has a story to tell, we'd love to hear from you; whether you'd like to give a personal interview or prefer to remain anonymous, simply write to us. Your personal experiences are culturally valuable and will be treated with the utmost respect. You can contact us with questions or information by writing to:

Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts
PO Box 88
Kempton, PA 19529

Hello to all of our readers!

The autumn is upon us. The summer has flown by, wet and cool. I am sure many of your gardens have been affected by the various blights and mildews. Although it has been trying in many ways at least we can be grateful that we have not had to contend with the droughts that are desiccating many other parts of our nation. And so we are entering the harvest with some spotty tomatoes and mildewy hay, but it is time to start putting up all the same.

This year has been a difficult one at Three Sisters, as many of our subscribers and attendees to our workshops and courses are having a hard time financially. We find the same comes true for us. We just keep moving forward, with the faith that these difficult times in our country and in our world will pass.

Despite the troubles, much has happened in the past few months. Matthew and Patrick have been spending most of their extra time building our house, which is now nearly in the framing stage (thank goodness it will be under the cover of a roof before winter!!!). The work has been constant and hard, but ultimately rewarding as they see the form of a home take shape through the labor of their own backs and the dexterity of their own hands.

Rob has been pursuing a teaching degree in order to participate in a small local school project. Jesse and Rob have been working together with several other parents and teachers to bring a school forth for our children which is oriented toward the traditional values of stewardship of the earth, cultural and religious tolerance, high quality education, and multilingualism. We will speak more to this project next issue, as things are developing.

I hope the coming autumn treats you well, and that the cold of the coming winter returns our gardens and our fields to a state of balance. Happy Fall 2009!

Blessings,

Jesse Tobin, Editor

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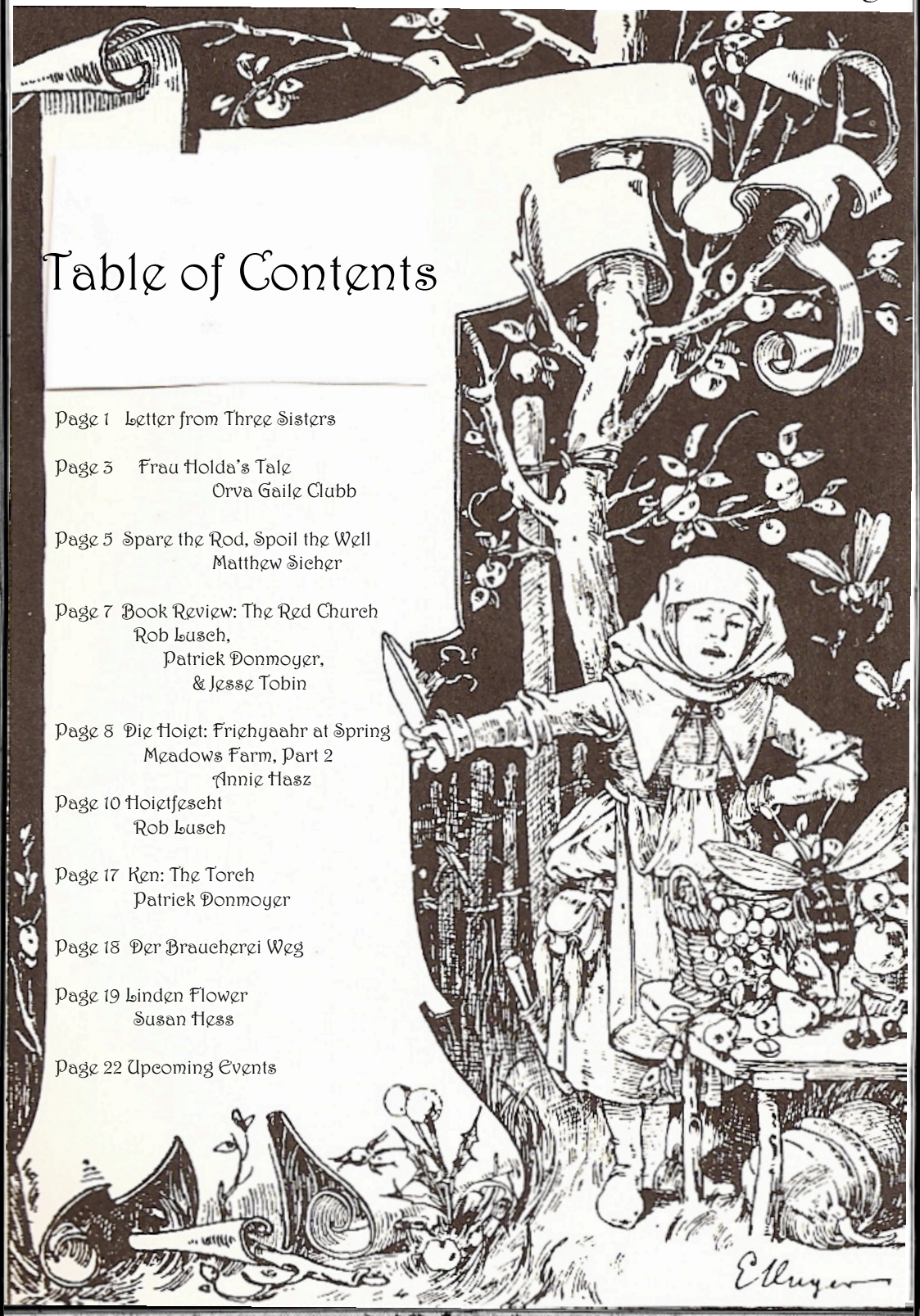
Translation of cover:

"What help are torchlight and glasses when people are unwilling to see?"



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Frau Holda's Tale By Orva Gaile Clubb

The article that follows is written by a recent apprentice to the Kutzeschteddel Raad of Brauchers. Orva Gaile Clubb grew up in a traditional Deitsch family of Brauchers in western Maryland. The following article was written upon her completion of Der Braucherei Weg course. Of late she has apprenticed with the Kutzeschteddel Raad to learn our prayers and healing ways. She has also shared a great deal with us, and we are grateful for her contributions to our ongoing revival work.

The Goddess spoke to me. Here are her words:

"We are of a long line. You are of this line. You are one of my children, my volk. This I entrust to you: My children do not know me. I have been forgotten to them. Bring my children back to me. Help them remember my ways. Help them find their way home."

Her message was very pointed and precise: I had been chosen and was given a sacred mission. As a professional genealogist I work with many people to help guide them in their efforts to find their linage. As a researcher in this field, I have found many ancestral lines for those who did not have the knowledge or expertise to do this work themselves. I took this message as a sacred charge: I must help those of German descent to find their lineage back to our Pennsylvania soil and ultimately to the rich soil of the Rhine.

The message was clear but I was initially unsure of who this mother goddess was who spoke to me. I later learned this was the voice of Frau Holda: Mother Goddess of the Palatinate Germanic Tribes; guardian over the souls of the departed and the unborn; mistress of the wild hunt.

In this work she has given me, it has proven imperative to embrace my heritage and learn the ways of those who went before me. I seek to take up the reins of my elders and renew this bond with tradition. I hope to learn the teachings and ways of my elders, wisdom that was almost forgotten to me. I want to give honor and respect to my ancestors, and the Gods and Goddesses who were sacred to them. The clearest path I can see is one that takes me through their ancient teachings. To ensure the wholeness of the future I must look deep into the past.

My feet are planted, and my course is set: to learn these ways and teachings, to rebuild a legacy, and to share this knowledge with generations to come.

The Sacred Journey and Migration of Frau Holda into our Modern Reality

Our modern understanding of Frau Holda comes to us from various sources. The earliest is sited in Jakob Grimm's *Teutonic Mythology*. We see this goddess with many names and attributes. Her legends are so well

renowned that we hear echoes of her in the great works of contemporary stories and even in the nursery tales we tell our children.

At one time Frau Holda held a place of paramount importance, as the Mother Goddess of the Germanic people. She still holds a place of reverence within Germanic culture and folklore, though in the mainstream her image has been diminished somewhat. As a steadfast guardian, she withstood the passage of the ages and has persisted as a mainstay of Germanic Spirituality and Beliefs. These traditional ways were maintained by the high and low born alike, despite centuries of persecution. Eventually Holda's folklore migrated with the Palatinate German peoples into a new world and time. She is seen in our traditional Deitsch legends and tales, she is essential to our healing arts as well as our agricultural practices. Her message of birth and re-birth, of the continuous wheel of life reflects the story of our agrarian worldview and our yearly journey through the seasons.

During centuries of persecution, the Christian orthodoxy has sought to demonize Holda, and to transform her in the mind of her people. Thus in some medieval accounts her image changed from the nurturing mother into a wicked hag, a devil worshiper, and the queen of the witches. This was done with a single-minded, focused intent to fragment and make impotent the folkways of central Europe.

In spite of these attempts, however, Holda persists in many areas of Deitsch culture, and is an important figure in the residual Heathen beliefs and customs, which pervade it. She is the rightful Mother Goddess of the Germanic people, and many of her children are now integrating her wisdom into their modern lives. Here we will discover the different aspects of her and her migration from the ancient past into modern day realities and society. I hope to show how her importance is vital to the discovery of the German experience and the unique spiritual and healing arts of the Braucherei tradition.

Holda is also a strong figure in the awakening heathen movement of the Deitsch people, a spiritual path known as "Urglaawe". "Der Urglaawe" literally means "the original faith" in the Deitsch language. Urglaawe is a Heathen movement that focuses on the pre-Christian religious and cultural undertones that still flow through the Pennsylvania German culture. Although the Pennsylvania Germans did not exist as a distinct ethnic group during the pre-Christian era, our ancestors brought with them many Heathen practices that continued to flourish here after the Diaspora into the Americas. (1)

Many of the Germanic folk have been scattered over vast distances. Currently through the age of computers, we are able to research and track ancestral links through genealogy. With this aid and guidance we can begin to understand the path our ancestors have trodden. This great journey has lead to us, the living generation, the present moment, the modern age. Within the belief system of Urglaawe this migration and evolution in culture is understood to have been driven by Frau Holda. It carried the core substance of her existence into our every day lives, and gave us the seeds from which we can re-grow the faith and tradition of our elders.

In Jakob Grimm's *Teutonic Mythology*, Holda is spoken of as host to the Wild Hunt or "Wilde Heer". In this account she is the consort of Woden, supreme god of the Germanic tribes occupying central Europe in ancient times. (2)

There are many variations of this story, but the themes that are most prominent are the ones that illustrate Holda leading a Wild Hunt to gather those souls that may still be lingering earth bound; and it is she who gathers them during this ride to usher them into the Other World. Another variation of this record is that she gathers unbaptized children, or more accurately, she gathers those born and who died without having been given a birth name, and takes them safely to the Other World.

continued on page 10.....

Spare the Rod, Spoil the Well

By Matthew Sicher

Many of the practices written within these pages are, in their application, dependent on sensitivity and discernment. Whether we engage in prayer healing work, herbal inquiry, or in the research into historical roots (potential and confirmed) of our practice, discernment is required. The same is true with the building process in which I am engaged. I've recently had the pleasure of trying my hand at another practice requiring sensitivity and discernment: dowsing.

A home must have water, and so when it came time to choose the location of the well, along with other considerations, I wanted the practice of dowsing to inform my decisions. I had spoken with a number of dowsers in the past, and attended a summer picnic two years ago hosted by the American Dowsers Society. Jesse and I were then invited to give a speech about the similarities in approach and orientation between Braucherei and Dowsing.

My Great Uncle Richard Groff has been dowsing for many decades now. Richard came into an appreciation for dowsing when he and Steve Groff (broad axe wielder extraordinaire) were first building his house. Appreciating the value of conscientious labor, they were hand-digging the well. However, when the second well attempt still yielded no water, Richard says he skeptically accepted the help of an older man nearby who was known to have skill with dowsing. After drilling the remainder of this final well, and finding clean and abundant water, Richard said he became convinced. And so it was with pleasure that I accepted Uncle's offer to come to our land to help dowse for our well.

We mostly worked with a freshly cut branch, Richard voicing that he preferred this most traditional of tools in dowsing work. After witnessing him find several points, and asking some questions, I tried my hand at it. Just like the Powwow work, I've been told you either possess an aptitude for dowsing or you do not. I was not surprised per se, but excited and intrigued to note how similar dowsing felt to Powwow work.

The tools and techniques used in both of these practices vary between individuals. Also I believe (and have been taught) that the tools and techniques do not make or break either practice, but act as tangible guides through which we may more accurately understand what is taking place. I too felt that I could most effectively work with a branch in dowsing, but the bent wires we tried also yielded results.

As points were discovered, I marked them in some way, to note a pattern. We found that the patterns created lines in different parts of the property. I focused on one of the areas, because for pragmatic reasons, that one area was most ideally suited for the placement of a well.

Uncle Richard also used the dowsing stick to inquire as to the potability of water

from that site, depth until clean water, and adequate flow. Just like with Powwow work, the extent of your work is largely dependent on your ability to read the subtleties of the experience, and creativity in application.

Even the well driller dowsed at the area we chose, also finding it suitable, and created a well with clean, abundant water (15 gallons per minute). With this tangible result, and my feeling of comfort with internal orientation required for dowsing, I will certainly work with it in the future.

I am excited for my practice to be expanding with the introduction of dowsing. I am also grateful to receive this knowledge, and look forward to teaching my kin in times to come. + + +

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* I must correct an error in my prior article about Uncle Richard and his house. He earned his Master's degree from Harvard, not a Doctorate. A small correction but one I wanted to clarify.

All Photographs by Jeffrey Sicher

Book Review: Chris Bilardi's The Red Church

From the View of Three Brauchers

by Rob Lusch, Patrick Donmoyer, and Jesse Tobin

Rob's View:

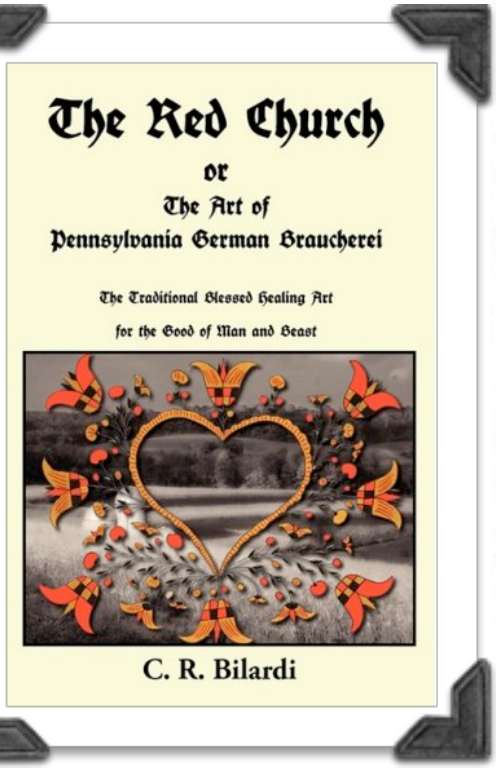
I admit it. I was surprised when I learned that Christopher R. Bilardi had published a book on Braucherei called, *The Red Church*. I had been acquainted with Mr. Bilardi only casually through the Hexenkunst Yahoo Group, which he had joined for a short time earlier this year. I was not aware at the time that he was authoring the book while lurking on our Yahoo Group.

If I was shocked to learn about the book, I was stunned when I saw its contents.

On the surface, the book appears to be well written; however, deeper reading reveals inconsistent spelling and dubious wisdom regarding some of the herbal remedies that appear in Chapter 10. The former could be dismissed as publishing errors or a lack of knowledge of German and Deitsch capitalization conventions. The latter is potentially of far more concern, and I would advise anyone considering following the herbal remedy advice to read and re-read Bilardi's caution on page 324: ***"Consult with your physician before engaging in an herbal regimen."*** Also on page 324: ***"A thorough knowledge of an herb and all of its properties is a must before engaging its use."*** For one example, I invite anyone interested to do simple research on the potential toxicity of comfrey.*

The rest of the book draws out several issues that gave me pause. One of the most important elements is the section on page 150 entitled "An Apologia." Bilardi implies that he essentially broke an oath to his mentor by publishing and apparently striving to copyright centuries-old chants and prayers without due respect to the traditional context from which they came. This rationalization is consistent with a general disrespect, which resurfaces throughout this work, toward the Braucherei forebears and to the Deitsch ancestors. Most notable is a statement made on page 152. In this selection, Bilardi is trying to excuse away the issue of his broken oath. The oath in question is one that we all have taken who have trained with Chris's teacher or her lineage of prayers. This oath is a promise to keep the prayers we are given in oral tradition only. Our students and apprentices may receive these prayers only when they have passed a test of sorts which shows that they are worthy in the eyes of spirit to receive these prayers. We are not to write these prayers down, and we are not to share them recklessly. Of this oath and its respect of the ancestors of our tradition, Bilardi writes the following:

> ***If "the ancestors" are killed off so easily when their words are written down, then they are not all that powerful to begin with.***



Is anything that weak worth surviving?"

Hm. Bilardi states in another area that he does not have a "Dutchy bone" in his body, so I suppose he does not mind making such potentially offensive statements about the Deitsch ancestors. I am not sure that similar statements would be so easily passed on about the ancestors of people of other ethnic extractions. As a proud Deitscher, I find this glib statement to be patently offensive. Living in Pennsylvania near Pennsylvania Germans does not make one a Pennsylvania German, particularly if our ancestors are the brunt of such comments.

Granted, I am a leader in the Urglaawe movement, which Bilardi clearly does not understand based on his footnoted reference to it (page 73). I noticed that, throughout the book, Bilardi omitted significant practices and beliefs of contemporary Braucherei that echo Heathen practices and maintain symbols, which he inconsistently disconnects from Braucherei in one place in the book and seems to reconnect again in another. (Come on…. These symbols did not come out of nowhere, and there is no way they mean nothing!).

Perhaps he did not have access to the high number of interviews that helped shape The Three Sisters Center's comprehensive overview of the realities of the practice. If he had indeed done so, he should have found the living, heathen traditions that thrived within the Deitsch culture. Bilardi did not openly interview any of the practitioners in the Center, so perhaps he only spoke to a limited number of Brauchers and Braucherins.

Thus, it appears that he does not understand the reality of Urglaawe as a living lens of surviving heathen practices rather than as a reconstructive movement. Although he was a member of our Yahoo Group for several weeks, he may not have been aware that we do not share all of our information without regard to the consequences of our actions. It is unfortunate that Bilardi did not make use of his contacts with me or other Urglaawers in order to understand the faith as it relates to the practice.

Then again, I also noticed what I perceived to be a general tendency in the book to omit or ignore the existence of a vibrant community of Brauchers and Braucherins. We do exist, and we exist within a wide variety of religious and philosophical stripes. It is unfortunate that this book provides, in my opinion, such a pedantic view of the practice. Save your money. + + +

***Bilardi, Christopher R., The Red Church. Sunland, CA: Pendraig Publishing, 2009**

***Comfrey was used traditionally as a tonic, but has recently been found to contain certain alkaloids that with overuse can cause an irreversible liver disease.**

Patrick's Thoughts:

Christopher R. Bilardi's *The Red Church* poses an ethical conundrum for our community of practitioners at the Three Sisters Center and for Braucherei practitioners throughout the world. Before his ethics are examined, our own ethical code needs to be explained in order to form a respectful comparison which acknowledges our own responsibilities. We at the Three Sisters Center have been entrusted with a body of scared ancestral wisdom which necessitates our sensitivity to the protocol by which we transmit the material. Some of the material is considered "open," and that means it can be respectfully shared with anyone in the community at large. The core body of ceremonial activity however, is strictly an oral tradition. These words and prayers have been entrusted to us under certain conditions, the first being that it not be written down, but rather be perpetuated *only* by word of mouth within the context of sincere apprenticeship. This means that only a person of the opposite gender can teach another, which reinforces and strengthens the gender equality of the practice. Healing is the primary purpose of this work, and it is not to be utilized for any purpose which compromises or seeks to undermine the wholeness of existence. This practice is not to be shared whimsically for personal gain, and we are under no

circumstances to request monetary payment for our services. This protocol has been in place for generations. Our teachers and instructors, who were gracious enough to pass their understanding and wisdom to us, specified these conditions. These ethical considerations have protected the practice from wholesale appropriation by those who would use it to further their own agendas. Some scholars have said that powwow is dead, or at the very least dying. This is not so. It is only largely invisible to those who would treat it as a curiosity to be isolated and dissected by empirical analysis. The protocol has preserved the practice, and we at the Three Sisters Center choose to honor our sacred agreement to perpetuate the practice accordingly. The practice is not in danger of dying out, hasn't been for hundreds of years, and so we feel no desperate urge to violate our oath and commit our sacred practice to print. To do so would be an ultimate act of immaturity and insecurity.

Christopher R. Bilardi however, has published an account of his Braucherei initiation, including words of the oral tradition which are not to be written down, and copyrighted them. His primary source for the oral tradition is an esteemed teacher familiar to us at the Three Sisters Center, whom he dishonors by deliberately publishing that which she had entrusted to him. She neither sanctioned or approved of his book. In a section of his writing aimed at examining the ethics of his work, he patronizingly dishonors and discredits those who have kept their oath and attempted to warn him of this violation of trust. We at the Three Sisters Center believe that the words of our prayers are a living embodiment of spirit, and to commit them to written word forces the sacred words to conform to a rigid, concretized form which lacks the capacity to grow under the protection of trust and sacred agreement. The words in written form subvert and make it possible to avoid the dynamic interaction of teacher and apprentice necessary to form a thorough understanding of the material. Christopher R. Bilardi's words are nothing more than a dead conglomeration of instructions and extortions, lacking a mature insight and even a rudimentary understanding of the original language. And so in the public eye the Braucherei tradition has been subjected to yet another layer of falsehood and distortions, motivated by insecurity over the persistence and steadfast nature of the tradition. Had he trusted in the wisdom of his teacher, he never would have made these errors. In his section entitled Apologia, he chastises the warnings of others that these words are the embodiment of our ancestors. He writes:

"if the ancestors are killed off so easily when their words are written down, then they are not all that powerful to begin with. Is anything that weak worth surviving?" (Bilardi 152)

These are not the words of a healer, or even a respectful historian. They are a disgraceful attempt at asserting the superiority of verbal discourse over traditional wisdom which transcends the bounds of earthly machinations.

Perhaps more dangerous than Christopher R. Bilardi's unsuccessful attempts to canonize the prayers, is that he uses his book as a vehicle to transmit his own opinions in conjunction with an explanation of the tradition. As it can be observed in the aforementioned quote, his opinions tend toward venomous criticism. To present the manifestation of his own need to denounce others side by side with information concerning Braucherei is inappropriate. Yet again, in the over-zealous attempt to "preserve" a tradition which is alive and well, a corrupted image of the tradition has been handed over to the public.

On the bright side, Christopher R. Bilardi's work is so riddled with numerous errors in syntax, spelling, German translation, interpretation and content that anyone attempting to use this book as a primary source would gain only a vague and incomplete understanding of the practice. His opinions concerning diverse subjects such as

Continued on page 14 ....

Hoietfescht (Urglaawe)

By Rob Lusch

This year, the local Urglaawe community observed the Hoietfescht on August 9 at Grings Mill Park outside of Reading, PA. Hoiet is the Deitsch word for haymaking or hay harvesting. As the first harvest is being collected, the haymaking process turns perishable remnants into storable goods and reduces the loss of nutrients and dry matter. This age-old practice extends the benefits of the crop and provides for feed over the winter months. Historically, even in the experience of some folks within our own community, the Hoiet (also called Summermit or Corn Boils) was a time of celebrating and being thankful for the gifts of the harvest. As in days gone by, the Hoiet time coincides with the arrival of new batches of root beer, birch beer, ginger beer, and ginger ale.

For Urglaawer, this is a time to give particular thanks to the Teutonic deities of the Wane (Vanir), who are recognized in old lore as the gods and goddesses of nature and worldly matters. Most closely associated with this time of year is the god Frey, who is recognized as the god of fertility. In fact, for many adherents to the faith of Asatru, the Hoietfescht is called Freyfaxi in His honor. Also honored, in addition to Frey, is His sister Freya, who is a captivating goddesses with many facets, including fertility, love, and beauty. At Hoietfescht, Urglaawer hail these sibling deities along with Their father, Njord, who sustains us through the fertility of rivers and streams. Over the centuries, the identities of the other Wane have been lost. It is possible, for instance, that Holle may be of the Wane, but no record is available to us at this time; however, our research continues.

Hoietfescht represents the end of the life cycle for the first crops. Their sacrifice will nourish us and the animals throughout the winter, and, in turn, we must respect their sacrifice and use the crops as much as possible. Between Hoietfescht and the autumn equinox, Urglaawe philosophy draws from the lessons of the Hoiet. We encourage individuals to begin to reap the benefits of life changes that had been effected since New Year's Day. While enjoying the positive changes in life (or while reflecting upon what was not successful), we are to give thanks for all the blessings that we have in our daily lives. This is a time for families and friends to come together to gather the bounty from the land and to prepare for the future. Much like we create hay from the vestiges of the harvest, we are to expand and improve our relationships within our community.

Blessings to all, and may all reap the benefits of deliberate, sustainable living!

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Photo credits to Peter Bivona

Frau Holda's Tale continued from page 4.....

Naming a child was a custom held by the Germanic clans that had great importance. It was traditional to name a child within nine days of giving birth to that child. The baby was then presented to the father and recognized as his own child. With this recognition the child would enter into the protection of his father's clan. If this child died before it was presented and named, it was believed that it would stay earth bound until Holda would ride on her mighty steed, leading the Wild Hunt, to gather all those in need of shepherding to the Other World. The

importance of childhood names and the protection of Frau Holda are both themes that remain vital and relevant even to contemporary understanding of Braucherei and other Deitsch folkways.

The fierce spectacle of the Wild Hunt must have been the most haunting of the dark night raids that the Roman General Tacitus spoke of in his first century accounts of the Germanic Tribes. (3) No doubt the image of dark raids with savage men dressed in animal skins and astride mighty steeds must have struck fear into the hearts and minds of any observer. This imagery was carried over into the early narrations of the Wild Hunt, by Christians who sought to further exaggerate this nebula of power and fear. Later the narrations would take on a sinister tone as the age of Christianity dominated the continent. This was a time when Gods and Goddesses became Demons and Witches in league with the Devil, who rode the skies on brooms and gathered souls for Satan's dark deeds.

None the less, the Wild Hunt has come to us in various forms, and in spite of the corruptions, Frau Holda is still honored in Germanic culture as she was in earlier times. Among the Heathenry of Germanic folk on both sides of the Atlantic she is known as the consort of Woden and is considered to be the Great Mother Goddess. Even among the Christian practitioners of the Deitsch folkways such as Braucherei, Frau Holda (or as she is known to the Deitsch "Hollerbeier Fraa") is central to traditional understanding of healing, spirituality, and agriculture.

Among the Deitsch, the Wild Hunt continues its ride, which is why we leave our windows open on Walpurgisnacht (April 30th), why we burn the Butzeman before Halloween, and why the Belschnickel visits at Christmas time. These customs echo the great wheel of the year that our ancestors knew intimately, with Frau Holda at the lead, driving ever forward.

The Many Names and Faces of Frau Holda:

There are many names and faces that can be attributed to Holda. In conducting this research I've found that there has been some disagreement and confusion in identifying Holda with other the supernatural beings known as Bertha and Perchta. Some sources indicate that Holda is not the same supernatural being, but rather that each is a separate being, independent of the others. From the information gathered, this assumption grew largely from differing viewpoints stemming from various regional interpretations denoting Holda's numerous attributes thus resulting in altered appearances and practices. However, Grimm in his *Teutonic Mythology* indicates that in actuality these supernatural beings are one and the same, reflecting different aspects or faces of the same Deity. Various regions thus identified Frau Holda differently as she was expressed in local terms. Grimm writes, "Similar to Holda , in the Upper German regions in Alsace and in Switzerland and Bavaria and Austria, she makes her appearance in a slightly different way. She is known as Perahta and Berchte." (4)

Some of the names she is known by are: Holda (the Merciful) Hulda, Hulla, Hulle Huld, Hulda, Holl, Holle, Bertha (the Bright) Berchte, Berta Brecht, Perchta, Perahta, Frau Holle, and (in the Deitsch Diaspora) Hollerbeier Fraa. (5) As discussed previously, the Germanic tribes considered Frau Holda to be the Great Mother Goddess, Leader of the Wild Hunt, and consort of Woden. Her work is to gather souls and to usher them to the otherworld. She is the matron of Motherhood and childbearing and of the housewife. Frau Holda is reputed to reside around Wells, Sacred Pools, and Springs that were believed to be the portals to the Other world. An obvious connection here can be found in *Grimm's Fairy Tales*, in their rendition of the story of *Mother Holle*. In this story, a girl falls down a well to find herself at the home of Mother Holle. She works diligently for Mother Holle and does everything that is asked of her. At the end of her stay she is rewarded with spectacular gifts. When her selfish and lazy stepsister sees this, she attempts to procure the same gifts for herself, she goes to the home of Mother Holle, but refuses to do the things that Mother Holle asks of her, or if she does them, she does them

poorly, and tries to cheat. Mother Holle rewards her with a bucket full of tar over the head as she leaves. In this sense Frau Holda could be seen as the giver of gifts (which is appropriate to the goddess of the earth, or mother goddess). She gives all that we have, and regulates the distribution of those gifts. It could also be said that she has a hand in teaching discipline to children as they grow.

Historically it was believed that newborns were first drawn form Frau Holda's pond (6), and that it was with her that each person departed this life as well. In the Braucherei Healing tradition, this same pond is thought to be a place of healing and sanctuary. She is still believed by many to be a protector of children and babies acting as a guardian until the time of their naming, and in many cases well after this time as well. According to some folklore she delivered newborns to their mothers at the time of childbirth, and could be seen riding on the back of a goose during this endeavor. In legend, Frau Holda is largely associated with Winter and in controlling the weather (she is responsible for making it snow). It was believed that when it snowed Frau Holle was shaking her feather bed. In a similar vein, the Goose is associated with her and is held sacred to her. The image of Frau Holda atop her goose survives still in the stories and rhymes of Mother Goose.

It was widely accepted that Holda presided over the hearth and home as the matron of Spinning, weaving, childrearing, and Domesticity. Holda is also associated with Agriculture as flax was held sacred to her, along with other crops that would give sustenance to humans and their livestock. Sometimes Holda is depicted as an old crone with long hair and teeth. She is often seen traveling in a wagon or with a plough. She is particularly associated with the art of spinning, which was historically an essential craft for every housewife to know.

Sometimes stories were told of an enraged and darker side Frau Holda who would break the spindles and burn or spoil the flax of those who did not finish their spinning

on time. Conversely, however, she was known to reward young women who were diligent and skilled in this craft. During the twelve days of Yule (a feast historically associated with Holda, Woden, and the Wild Hunt) all spinning and textile work was to come to a halt until the end of the festivities in honor of her most sacred season. It was believed that those who did any spinning or weaving during this time would have bad luck for the whole of the coming year.

Forests have always held a great importance to the German people. Our ancient ancestors worshiped in groves where certain trees were held sacred and were believed to be filled with Spirit. This belief in the spirits within the plant world persists in Braucherei in the practice of *Blanzeschwetze* (speaking with plants). Many native European plants are associated with Holda, and many of these are among the most highly revered plant spirits in contemporary practice. The Elderberry is such a tree and is particularly sacred to Frau Holda for its wise old "Elder" spirit that renewed itself and brought forth new blossoms of white flowers each Spring. In the Pennsylvania Deitsch language the tree is referred to as *Hollerbeier Schtock.* Elder is a veritable medicine chest, as each part of the shrub has different medicinal properties. During the time of Charlemagne, it was mandated as law that

every homestead was required to grow an elder near the house.

The Holly tree is another sacred tree. In the winter these evergreen branches are hung throughout the Yule season to remind us of the the coming rebirth of the living world. In this way, Holda (Holle) is honored in each home that continues this practice.

The Rose is also among the plants that are associated with her, known as *Frau Rose* or Mother Rose. In folklore, those who care for a rose bush are believed to be blessed by Frau Holda. To pick a flower one should seek permission from Holda or else great misfortune will follow. Once again demonstrating the merciful and dark side of the Goddess.

With demonization of Holda in Christian times, the Wild Hunt (once a sacred yearly cycle) became the unleashing of vengeful and spiteful host whose allegiance resided with the devil himself. Holda was believed by many Christians to be in league with Satan and was called Queen of the Witches, and was believed to sit at the head of her own cult. Holda is often linked to Brocken mountains, which is reputed by Christian witch hunters to be a main gathering place for witches. Here it is clear to see how Frau Holda fell from grace due to the dominance of the Roman Catholic Church.

In the realm of Orthodoxy, the old Heathen ways were exterminated or integrated and absorbed into Christian practice and observances. Interestingly, this demonization did not happen across the board. While the orthodoxy of the Church and the witch hunters feared Holda, her people loved her. The split that happened to her is one that can be observed with many heathen deities: the unacceptable aspects were demonized, while the benign aspects were allowed to persist in folklore. The Germanic people clung to Holda, and wove her into legends that were handed down from generation to generation and carried on in oral tradition.

She comes to us now in the form of well known written works and literature such as "*Kinder- und Hausmärchen"* (*Children's Household Tales*), by Jakob Grimm. Her lessons survive as well in the oral history tradition of the Deitsch and other Germanic peoples.

The story of Holda is one that leads us to live in harmony with the seasons and tides of the earth. It also shows us the persistence and tenacity of spirit of a people, and the power of their steadfast will. These attributes of Germanic folklore stem from the very ancient core of our Germanic Consciousness and beliefs. The matron of home and hearth, turns her great wheel, spinning her raw flax into the ever-changing seasons of life: she readies the soil, plants the seed, tends the crop, reaps the harvest, and mills the germ from the chaff in an unbroken circle of life.

She calls to us, the pulsing heartbeat of the earth herself; she shows us a new path that grows from the old, one that honors the cycles and rhythms of nature, one that teaches us that it is only through the earth that we may be as one with all who have gone before, and all who are yet to be. + + +

Footnotes:

[1] Traditions Within Heathenism, Der Urglaawe , by Rob Lusch; http://www.thortrains.com/utmo/Urglaawe.htm or http://www.Urglaawe.org

[2] Brothers Grimm, http://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Brothers_Grimm

[3, 4] Grimm, *JacobTeutonic Mythology,* Vol. 1-1V translated from 4th edition by James S. Stallybrass, George Bell& Sons, London 1883: http://www.Northvegr.org.

[5] Reginheim, Erda/ Holda/ Frigg: http://www.geocities.com/reginheim/erda.html

[6] *Holda* by Dianna L. Paxton :

Note: *Volk:* people/ tribe of the homeland.

Book review continued from page 9.....

the Teutonic origins of Braucherei, the significance of Barn Stars, the mystery of the Sator palindrome, the significance of the Runes, Pennsylvania architecture, and (seriously,) a comparison of Braucherei to instant mashed potatoes, leave much to be desired. His ideas are presented as research, when often they amount to a narrow selection of sources, aiming at speaking for the Pennsylvania Dutch as a whole, which is problematic.

This brings another unfortunate element of Christopher R. Bilardi's "research" to the forefront: While his introductory assessment of the migration patterns of the Pennsylvania Dutch is well-constructed, it merely regurgitates an already well-documented history of the people, and offers nothing that hasn't already been published in other books. His introduction is telling, however, as he reveals that he does not have a "dutchy bone" in his body. In this sense, his aforementioned irreverence to our ancestors can be put into the proper context. They are not his ancestors, and this explains his insensitivity and belligerent language. Bilardi seems to have anticipated a negative response from current practitioners. His unethical treatment of the Braucherei tradition taints any positive contribution his book could have fostered. This relegates his text to yet another feeble attempt at cultural exploitation for the purpose of self-aggrandizement. Any discerning reader will easily recognize that Christopher R. Bilardi's account is too fundamentally flawed to gain him the attention he seeks. + + +

Jesse's Perspective:

Of the three of us who have shared our views here, I am the only one who has a personal connection to Chris Bilardi. It is because of this connection that I feel the need to share my review of his newly published book. I met Chris Bilardi about a year ago when he and his wife came to meet Matthew and me for an early dinner. The reason for our meeting was our shared interests in Braucherei as well as our shared teacher. Chris and Matthew are two of only three men this particular teacher has ever trained (the third is also a member of the Three Sisters Raad). Chris is a nice guy, I have no quarrels with him on a personal level. I think he is friendly and well-meaning, though misguided in his attempts to share the Braucherei tradition.

Mine are not feelings of anger toward Chris or his book. My Libran brothers have voiced strong indignation that comes, I am sure, from a sense of injustice: of a community wronged and taken advantage of. I can certainly see their points. I also see Chris's publication and copyright of his work as somewhat akin to the Monsanto Corporation's practice of usurping and patenting of heirloom crops. In both places, there is an attempt to use the power of the recorded word to claim control over that which cannot be controlled, that which is inherently now and ever shall be the property of the folk.

I must say that one small comfort I found is that Chris somewhat altered our traditional prayers before he wrote them down. He also does not have information about many of our traditional ceremonies, and so these have not been befouled by this rendering of living spirit into bound and printed flesh.

My feelings are those of disappointment. Matthew and I both attempted to dissuade Chris from his decision to publish. We tried to help him see that this was not a decision he was licensed to make alone, but one instead that requires the voice of all the Braucherei community (from which we've repeatedly heard a resounding "*NO*" to the idea of publication). I attempted to remind him of his oaths. I sought to appeal to his respect for the elders who have passed on the oral tradition for generations. All this effort was to no avail. At the very least, I appealed to him to publish only that which was acceptable to be shared openly in accordance with the wishes of the elders. An easy rule here would be to stick to that which he has personal

knowledge of (this would not include herbal remedies, as he is neither doctor nor herbalist), and that which has *not* been expressly forbidden to publish or given in confidence. He decided to ignore these inconveniences, regardless of how obviously central to the integrity of the written word they are. Though these concepts have guided Braucherei for centuries, Chris went forward with his intentions with disregard for respect of tradition.

Even more, I was saddened by his attack on the perspectives held by all of us at the Three Sisters Center. Upon meeting Chris I had hoped we could work together toward a common goal of the continuation and revival of Braucherei. With the treatment our lineage and beliefs are given in his book, however, my hopes are dashed.

My perspective within Braucherei is one of a Christian mystic. There is room in my heart and spirit for many different ways of understanding. Though I do not count myself exclusively among the Urglaawe community, I do not scorn it. I am greatly impressed by the work of Rob Lusch: with a seemingly inexhaustible source of energy he digs into his research and shares his Heathen Deitsch wisdom, not to mention many other contributions to a Deitsch cultural revival. His worldview is one that is firmly rooted in Deitsch culture and Braucherei tradition, but focuses primarily on the Pre-Christian aspects of the culture and tradition that still live within the folds of the dominant Deitsch worldview.

Most of all I feel a sense of sadness for Chris himself. He can never take these words back. He has locked himself into his decision and course of action by the publication of his book. I do not pretend to know what that means for his personal practice, faith, or connection to the elders. I am sure, however, that any sense of trust and connection with the Braucherei community he once enjoyed has been broken by this work. I pray that though this trust is broken, that the Braucherei community can find forgiveness for Chris in time. + + +

Die Hoiet: Hay-Making Part II of the Season at Spring Meadows

By Annie Hasz

It has been a summer season of learning patience, as the cold nights have delayed the ripening of summer vegetables and wet weather has made hay-making difficult and somewhat tedious.

Our second evening of haymaking at Spring Meadows Farm began with the tackle breaking. I did a rough splice-job on this essential rope, drawing on my hair-braiding experience, and we continued loading hay until nearly midnight. Rain was expected in the early morning so there was no possibility of waiting.

Ideally the process of making loose hay with oxen at Spring Meadows goes like this: the oxen pull a brush mower to knock the hay down in the cool of early morning or evening. As soon as the hay dries, the oxen pull a rake which draws the hay into fat windrows. Next, we go out with our pitchforks and load the hay onto a sled pulled by the oxen. Our first sled was 7 feet long and made of concrete-reinforcing wire. We destroyed this after several heavy loads of damp hay. Now, we are using a cattle panel cut to the same length. We roll the hay into stacks along the windrows and lay it on the sled in a pattern similar to laying shingles, each forkful overlapping the other one slightly. We pack the hay down by stomping and continue until the load is heaping full. At the barn, we unhook the oxen from their chain and re-hook them with the chain pulled over the top of the load. When they walk forward, the load rolls up neatly as the sled is pulled away.

Once the loads are piled under the open door of the hay mow, we pull the hay

harpoon out the door and down to the piles. Andy drives the harpoon into a pile and latches it. The harpoon rope, or tackle, runs through pulleys, along the spine of the barn, then out through the barn's south side and through another pulley almost at ground level. We attach a clevis (a heavy-duty ring and bolt) to this end of the tackle and it can hook up to the oxen. When the load has been speared, Andy yells to me and I drive the oxen forward to a marked spot in the barnyard. They pull the load up in the hay mow and voila!

One weekend, Andy mowed and raked hay on a Saturday morning only to watch a sudden storm blow in and soak it all. The next morning was sunnier than expected, so we tedded the hay (threw it with pitchforks to fluff and dry it) and left it for a couple hours. Then Andy raked it again with the oxen and we rolled it into piles and began loading the sled. The sky darkened. We were racing another storm. We got ¾ of the hay to the barn before the skies opened. We covered these piles with a tarp and watched the rest get soaked for the second time as thunder boomed. The next day we tedded the remainder twice more, re-raked and piled it and finally loaded it in the barn and leveled it out, throwing forkfuls to hang on all the rafters.

Tonight we are hauling in the last of the hay in dry weather with clear skies. Spring Meadows has about 20 acres in haylands, but because of the wet summer and the demands of the vegetable garden we have hayed less than half of this. Last week we got a delivery of 200 bails from the neighbor up the road. Years ago his family used to hay this whole valley with a team of horses. He is one of the few in the area who got the timing right in this demanding hay-making season.

+ + +

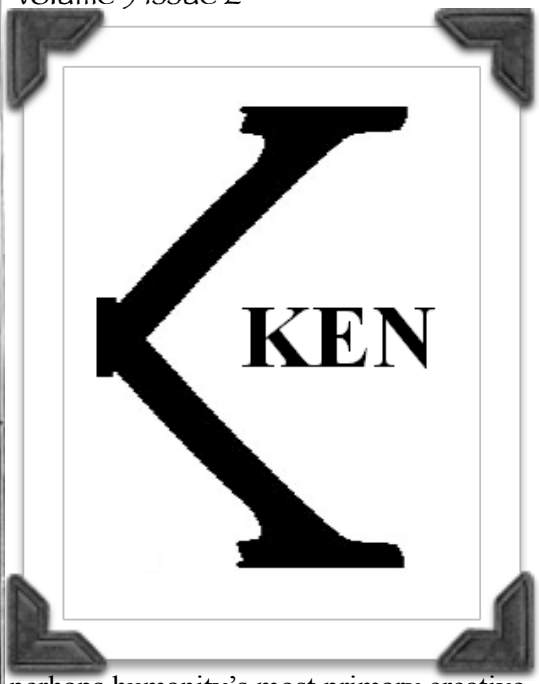
KEN: The Torch

By Patrick Donmoyer

"The torch to all living is pale and bright,
It burns brightest,
Where noble folk rest."

-Anglo-saxon Rune Poem
Thomas Howard Translation

The sixth rune is Ken, and its literal translation from the original language is Torch. It is also etymologically similar to two other words still in use in the PA Deitsch Language: ***kenne***, to know, and ***kenne*** to be able. The torch can be understood as a symbol of active, transportable fire, especially that which is controlled by humans. The creation and manipulation of fire is one of humanity's most essential skills, forming a basis for working with diverse materials such as metals, ceramics and wood. Fire enables humans to transform their world around them. Another Pennsylvaanisch Deitsch word with a similar derivation is ***Kunscht,*** literally meaning art or skill. This rune therefore presides over humans and their creative activities. In this sense, fire is also compared to the human procreative capacity, as it is



perhaps humanity's most primary creative impulse. It is not coincidence that this rune is sixth in the series. The number 6 has been regarded by many cultures as representing creative capacities. In Judeo-Arabic cultures there were 6 days of creation, giving rise to concepts such as the creation star, or the star of David. In Germanic cultures the 6th day of the week is named Friday for the goddess Freya who presides over love and marriage. Ken has been related to the element of fire, as transmissive and active, of positive polarity. As both a metaphor for progenitive ability and constructive creative tendency, fire becomes a means to multiply energy by unlocking creative potential. Whether it is the creation of a child, or the building of a house, an enxtension of one's spirit is established with a hope of continuation. Fire links each successive generation through the transmission of knowledge. Ken is a metaphor for enlightenment, the inherent human ability to transform one's self.

In divination, Ken can represent an active potential, an immanent possibility, an offer or opportunity for energy exchange. If one seeks insight into a situation, Ken addresses the unfolding of the energy exchange to follow. If one is seeking to expend energy for any purpose, whether in a project that requires work, in a performance, or in a relationship, Ken can indicate the outcome of the energy. Ken can also apply to energy being directed your way by another, and what an appropriate course of action should be. It most importantly addresses whether that energy is being maximized and expended effectively. As with most runes, Ken has upright and inverted capacities. In the most simplistic sense, Ken can indicate a positive or negative outcome to energy expenditure. In a more expanded sense however, positive and negative outcomes are often a matter of perception. Ken asks us to evaluate our motivations and expectations. If Ken is inverted, it need not portend loss. It can indicate that one must evaluate their expectations and examine what is at stake. If Ken is upright it doesn't necessarily imply success, it can indicate a need to focus on the objective outcome in order to advance. In the study of the runes, an overly simplistic sense of duality can form if one pays more attention to orientation than to metaphor. The metaphor, when applied to experience, forms a comparison which provides the context for the implication of upright and inverted qualities. This complexity can be magnified when each rune is considered in conjunction with other runes in the casting. The runes always reveal a network of meanings.

+ + +

Three Sisters Center for the Healing Arts Presents:

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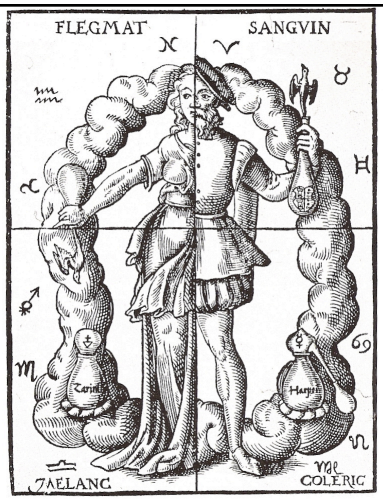
+++ Early Pennsylvania Braucherei

+++ Native American influence

+++ Twentieth century Braucherei

+++ Differentiation between Braucherei and Hexerei



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Der Braucherei Weg is now available to distance students, Contact Jesse for more information!

Linden Flower

Tilia europaea, Tilia americana,

Limeflower, American Basswood **By Susan Hess**

The Linden is a deciduous tree growing to 100 ft with smooth gray bark, heart-shaped leaves, and clusters of pale, very sweet smelling yellow flowers with wing-like bracts. Linden, otherwise known as American Basswood here in the States, is a very valuable bee plant, producing an abundance of nectar. Also a valuable species for wildlife, there are 31 species of insects associated with this tree.

In ancient times, the Linden tree played an important role in Germanic mythology. This is especially true in the north where it frequently replaced the Birch as being sacred to Freya, the Goddess of love and fertility and also, to Holle, the mother Goddess of death and rebirth. In ancient marriage traditions, the Linden played an important role as a sacred witness to the rites. This is unsurprising, considering the link to Freya. In the Middle Ages, the tree was still considered the symbol of loving couples, who stood under its canopy of heart shaped leaves to declare undying love. Traces of this ancient custom were still evident as late as the 1930's in remote areas of France, where bridal couples passed beneath two Lindens whose upper branches had become entwined, in the belief that this would bring never-ending blessings and happiness to the marriage.

Just as the Linden was known as the tree of couples love, it was also known as the birth tree. It was customary to plant the tree (of life) when a child was born. In the Lauenberg region of Germany, it was the custom to plant a Linden tree on the birth of a baby girl so that she would soon marry under it!

In Germany, France and Belgium, it was traditional to plant a Linden tree on the first day of May and to celebrate there was often much singing and dancing of young people around the tree afterwards. Perhaps this was the early beginnings of the May Pole. Nearly every village had a square with a linden tree as the central focus. It was under these trees that the townsmen met to decide business and judges sat to listen to charges and pass judgements. (Therapeutically, Linden blossoms have a sedative effect on the nervous system and gently lower blood pressure. Anyone who has ever attended a heated town meeting or a trial can well understand the need for this type of calming presence!)

The healers of the time once made it common practice to use a trowel made of linden wood for digging up herbs which could cure illnesses caused by the casting of evil spells. In sympathetic medicine, it was thought that Linden was 'the great mediator'. It was believed that all pain, ill will and sickness could be transferred to the tree. To do this, an iron nail was rubbed on the affected person's painful spot, broken bone, etc. The nail was driven by three swift strikes into the trunk of the Linden tree with a small bit of the person's bandage or cloth then hung upon the nail.

One particularly ancient Linden in the Belgian village of Soleilmont had been visited by many generations of pilgrims, who traveled far and wide for this purpose. It was discovered that over its long life, approximately seventy thousand nails had been driven into the enormous Linden trunk for the transference of pain or malady and still remain living until it was cut down and destroyed in 1922.

For our simple purposes today, the flowers/petioles can be gathered on a dry day when they are fully opened but before they are withered, usually mid to late June. The flowers are classified as a calming agent to the nervous system, a carminative for the digestive system, an antispasmodic, a mild anti-depressant and one that gently lowers fevers and minor high blood pressure. It can also be helpful to cheer one who has "The Blues" when combined with lemon balm. Linden flower is a very mild, wonderfully sweet-tasting herb! It is gentle enough for both young children and the elderly. It is the perfect herbal choice for children that suffer with ADD or for children who are feverish but with the addition of excitability or irritability. Linden blossom is helpful for anyone who has a hard time winding down at the end of the day and thus experiences insomnia, anxiousness and hyperactivity. Linden has been proven to reduce hypertension associated with nervous tension as well as nervous headaches, nervous bellyaches and nervous gagging or vomiting.

***Tea Making Suggestion**: You can make a lovely tea with 2tsp dried Linden flowers covered with a cup of boiling water and steeped for about15-20 minutes. You can enjoy 2-4 cups per day, sweetened with honey, if desired.*

If you are fortunate to have access to a Linden tree in your neighborhood, you may also make a very pleasant tasting elixir of Linden blossoms. See directions below:

Sweet Nerve-ana Elixir

Fill a glass quart-size Mason jar with freshly picked Linden Blossoms. They should be strongly fragrant and sweet. Cover the blossoms with good quality brandy ¾ of the way to the top of the jar .This would be approximately 3 cups. (I use E&J brandy) Fill the jar the rest of the way with a light, mild-tasting honey (approximately one cup). Screw the lid on the jar and shake the contents well to assure that the honey and the brandy have blended well. Store in a cool dark location for a month, shaking it occasionally. Strain the infused brandy through cheesecloth to catch all of the flower pieces. Rebottle the elixir into a clean jar. Sip a small ½ oz. cordial glassful as needed. This is truly a tasty elixir. Enjoy!

"Tiliae sub tegmine tutus"
~It is safe to sit under a Linden~
-from an early Roman document extolling the many protective virtues of the Linden tree

+ + +

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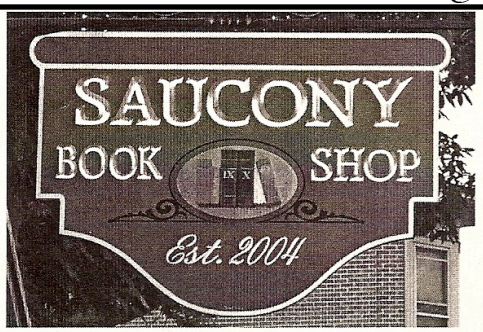

The Saucony Book Shop, located in the heart of scenic rural Berks County, epicenter of Pennsylvania German folk culture, offers a full range of gently used, rare, and antiquarian books, with many volumes of scholarly merit and an unabashed emphasis on the quaint, the curious, and the utterly obscure.

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Hollerbeier Haven Guild Gatherings June to October 2009

September 26th: Urglaawe- "the Original Faith

September's gathering will focus on "Urglaawe" or "Original Faith". Urglaawe is a heathen faith based upon Continental Germanic and Pennsylvania German tradition. Rob Lusch will be sharing his knowledge of Urglaawe with us during this gathering. He has been working tirelessly to establish Urglaawe as a recognized faith, and to revive and educate others about its evolution, beliefs, and practices of Urglaawe. We will be discussing the long-standing beliefs and traditions that are central to Urglaawe and their relevance in modern life.

October 31st: Psychic Self Defense

Everyday we swim through a sea of energy, emotion, and thought. Waves of energy and emotion connect us all to each other often in healthy and beneficial ways, but not always. Despite this, most people of today's world do not consider or concern themselves with thoughts of psychic psychic self-defense. October's gathering will focus on methods of spiritual self-defense from the Braucherei tradition. We will cover a variety of practices from charms and sympathies to the breaking of hexes, as well as the use of seasonal work in psychic self-defense.

November 14th, 2009:

Traditional Architecture of the PA Deitsch: Heirlooms of Green Building

November's gathering will discuss the unique architecture of the PA German people. We will look that the many traditional building techniques and designs such as bank barns, cellar kitchens, summer kitchens, root cellars, etc. We will examine the specificity of these architectural elements to Pennsylvania's climate, and their modern application in green building design.

The Asatru and Urglaawe Meet-up Group of Eastern Pennsylvania and NJ is planning its annual food drive and autumn equinox celebration for September 19, 2009. Details are still being finalized, but the event will be in Berks County. More information may be found on the group's website (http://asatru.meetup.com/249/). The celebration coincides with the Urglaawe Erntfescht (Harvest Home) and Asatru's Winter Finding. This event is being organized by Haukafell Kindred and Distelfink Sippschaft. Food products will be donated to the Greater Berks Food Bank.

All Guild Gatherings with the exception of June's will be held from 10 am to 3 pm at Indigo Natural Healing Center near Kutztown, PA.
The cost for attendance is $35 for Hollerbeier Haven Subscribers, and $45 for non-subscribers. For more information, contact Jesse Tobin: 484-336-4611

Three Sisters Center
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